

MY LIFE SERVICES

ILS Service Note Documentation Training

Independent Living Skills Program · Staff Training

Why Your Notes Matter

1

Document the service

Your note is the record that the service you provided actually happened.

2

Support billing

Notes must match the time billed. Billing is built on what you write.

3

Show client progress

Notes demonstrate movement toward the client's ISP goals over time.

4

Keep MLS compliant

Notes must meet Regional Center requirements. Weak documentation puts the agency at risk.

THE BASIC RULE

Document what you did, why you did it, how you supported the client, and what happened as a result.

What We'll Cover Today

- 1 How the note system works
- 2 What every entry must contain
- 3 Writing about the client, not yourself
- 4 Naming the type of support
- 5 Approved language: transportation
- 6 Completing notes before clock-out
- 7 In-person is the standard
- 8 Being objective
- 9 History, needs, and follow-up
- 10 Documenting important changes
- 11 When a client doesn't respond
- 12 Things you must never do
- 13 What not to write
- 14 Skill areas and sample language
- 15 The pre-submit checklist
- 16 Attestation and sign-off

1

How the Note System Works

At the end of each shift you open the Daily Service Note for that client. The client's personalized ISP goals appear as a list.

STEP 1

Mark Yes or No

for each goal, based on whether you actually worked on it that day.



STEP 2

Write 1–3 sentences

for every goal you mark Yes, explaining the support and instruction you provided.



STEP 3

Match the full shift

Your entries together should reflect the whole shift and match the time you billed.

Only mark Yes for goals you actually worked on.

There is no problem with marking No. There is a serious problem with marking Yes for a goal you did not address.
If your shift genuinely covered only two goals, mark two.

2

What Every Entry Must Contain

Each entry is short, but it still has to answer these questions.

1

What skill was practiced?

2

What did the client do?

3

What support or teaching did staff provide?

4

How did the client respond?

5

What needs to happen next? (when there is follow-up)

Priority

You will not always fit all five into three sentences.

Prioritize 1 through 4.

Add the follow-up when it matters for the next session.

Prioritize questions 1 through 4, and add the follow-up when it matters for the next session.

What a Complete Entry Looks Like

One goal, three sentences, every question answered.

✓ EXAMPLE ENTRY

“Client reviewed her bank balance and upcoming bills with staff. Staff provided verbal prompts to help client identify which bills were due before her next paycheck; client identified rent and phone independently but needed assistance recognizing two automatic payments. Staff will follow up next session on whether the bills were paid.”

Length is not the measure. A three-sentence entry that answers the questions is stronger than a paragraph that describes the day.

Every question, answered

- **Skill practiced**
Money management — reviewing balance and bills
- **What the client did**
Identified rent and phone independently
- **What staff did**
Provided verbal prompts
- **Client response**
Needed assistance with two automatic payments
- **Follow-up**
Staff will check whether bills were paid

3

Write About the Client, Not Just Yourself

A note that only describes staff activity does not show that ILS is building the client's skills.

✗ WEAK

“Staff took John grocery shopping.”

No skill named. No client participation. No support described. No response recorded.

✓ STRONG

“John developed a grocery list with staff support and accompanied staff to the grocery store. John located most items independently and requested assistance comparing prices on several items.”

Ask yourself: does my note show what the CLIENT did, or only what I did?

4

Name the Type of Support You Provided

"Staff assisted client" says nothing. Explain how you assisted.

Staff supported client...

Staff demonstrated...

Staff guided client...

Staff prompted client
to...

Staff reviewed with
client...

Types of support you can name in a note

Verbal prompting

Modeling

Demonstration

Reminders

Education

Problem solving

Researching options

Reviewing information

Role-playing

Community-based instruction

Public transit instruction

Advocacy

Assistance making appointments

Communicating with providers

Follow-up from last session

5

Approved Language: Transportation

My Life Services is not a transportation provider.

Documentation must never suggest that transportation was the service being delivered.

The wording you choose matters even when the underlying activity was appropriate. A note that reads like a transportation log describes a service the agency is not authorized to provide.

Transportation: Say It This Way Instead

Same activity, correct wording.

✕ NEVER WRITE

“Staff drove client...”

“Staff picked up client...”

“Staff dropped off client...”

“Staff transported client...” · “provided a ride...”

✓ WRITE INSTEAD

“Staff accompanied client to...”

“Staff met client at...”

“Staff assisted client with accessing transportation...”

Rewrite the sentence around the skill you taught.

Getting somewhere is never the service. What you taught on the way there or once you arrived is the service.

Teaching Transportation Is a Legitimate ILS Skill

The instruction counts. The ride does not.

✓ DOCUMENT THIS

- Helping a client plan a bus route
- Reading a bus or train schedule
- Using a transit card
- Waiting safely at a stop
- Using a route-planning app

This is instruction, and it should be documented as such.

✗ NEVER DOCUMENT THIS

Providing the transportation itself.

It is not a service, and it must not appear in the note — no matter how the sentence is worded and no matter how necessary the trip was to the session.

If the only thing that happened was travel, there is no ILS service to document. Talk to your supervisor.

6 Complete Your Notes Before You Clock Out

You cannot clock out of a direct service shift until your notes for that shift are complete.

Notes are written at the end of the session, while the shift is still fresh — not reconstructed later from memory. This is both a payroll requirement and a compliance requirement. A shift without a completed note is not a finished shift.

Your documentation must accurately reflect:

✓ The actual date of service

✓ The actual times services were provided

✓ Where services occurred

✓ The client who received the service

✓ The support actually provided

✓ The client's participation and response

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In-Person Is the Standard

ILS shifts are provided in person, either at the client's home or in the community. Both count as in-person service.

Non-in-person services are documented differently.

Those requirements are covered in the QSP Documentation and Scheduling Guide. Do not write them up as a standard ILS session note.

Never document a call, an attempted contact, or a no-show as an in-person session.

If you did not see the client, document what actually occurred and notify your supervisor.

Anything other than in-person service requires prior supervisor approval.

This includes telephone contact, video or remote contact, or any other arrangement.

Without prior approval the shift will not be accepted as worked, no matter what you write. Approval cannot be obtained after the fact.

8

Be Objective

Document facts and observations — not judgments or conclusions about why someone behaved a certain way. Do not diagnose, label, or speculate about motives.

✗ JUDGMENT

“Client was lazy and didn't want to work on his budget.”

“Client was rude.”

✓ OBSERVATION

“Client declined to work on budgeting during today's session and stated he wanted to address the goal at the next visit.”

Write what you saw

Actions, words, and responses you directly observed.

Quote when it helps

What the client said is a fact. Why they said it is a guess.

Leave out the why

Motive, mood, and diagnosis are not yours to record.

9 Maintain History, Understand Needs, Follow Up

ILS is a continuing process, not a series of unrelated visits.

1

Maintain a history

Review prior notes so you know what has already been done.

2

Understand the client's needs

Know their ISP goals, strengths, preferences, and current circumstances.

3

Follow up

If something was started at a previous session, find out where it stands.

What continuity looks like

PREVIOUS VISIT

Client and staff completed a housing application.



NEXT VISIT

Staff asks whether a response was received, supports client in checking status, and helps identify the next step.

A note about future plans you did not act on is not billable. A short line about genuine follow-up is expected.

10

Document Important Changes

Note significant changes that may affect services, and notify your supervisor when a situation needs follow-up or may require an incident report.



Change in housing



Hospitalization



Medical concerns



Changes in benefits



Employment changes



Safety concerns



Behavioral or emotional concerns



Change in phone or contact info



Trouble accessing basic needs

A significant change in the client's ability to work on an ISP goal

Document the change in the note, then notify your supervisor. Do not assume someone else already has.

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If a Client Does Not Respond or Attend

Does not answer

Does not show up

Refuses services

Stops responding

You must do both of these:

1

Contact a supervisor

Not later, not at the end of the week. Reach out when it happens.

2

Document what actually occurred

Including the fact that you contacted your supervisor, and when.

If you find an error in a note you already submitted

Contact your supervisor and follow MLS procedures for correcting the record. Do not alter it on your own.

12

Never Do These

Any one of these is a documentation integrity violation.

- ✗ Document a service, activity, or contact that did not occur
- ✗ Copy and paste a previous note and submit it as new — repeated notes are noticeable and get flagged in review
- ✗ State that a client was present when they were not
- ✗ Adjust service times to match a schedule when the actual times were different
- ✗ Document progress you did not observe
- ✗ Sign another employee's documentation
- ✗ Use ChatGPT or other AI to write your notes — AI-generated notes are usually obvious and do not accurately reflect the session you provided

13 What NOT to Write: Long Narratives About the Day

✗ WHAT NOT TO WRITE

“Staff accompanied client to Walmart where client bought groceries and walked around the store for a while. Then staff drove client to Target so client could look for shoes. After that staff and client went to lunch and talked before ending session.”

What's wrong with it

- Contains a transportation violation (“drove”)
- Does not explain what skill was taught
- Does not explain how staff assisted
- Does not identify which goals were addressed
- Describes a day, not a service

Vague filler and opinions

“Staff assisted client.”

“Staff talked with client about goals.”

“Client was difficult today.”

None of these tell a reviewer what was taught, what the client did, or what happens next.

Common ILS Skill Areas and Sample Language

These are examples, not a checklist.

The goals in your note come from the individual client's ISP. The areas below are common categories with sample sentences you can draw language from.

Community Resource Awareness

Staff supported client in locating the nearest food bank and prompted client through calling to ask about eligibility. Client asked two of three prepared questions independently.

Independent Recreation

Staff guided client in searching online for free community events and demonstrated how to save an activity to the phone calendar. Client added one event with minimal prompting.

Self-Advocacy

Staff role-played with client how to ask questions at an upcoming appointment. Client practiced three questions aloud and wrote them down to bring with her.

Time Management / Organization

Staff supported client in setting medication alarms and adding two appointments to his calendar. Client entered the second independently after staff modeled the first.

Skill Areas and Sample Language

Continued — health, hygiene, money, and shopping.

Health — Medical / Dental

Staff accompanied client to a cardiology appointment with Dr. Smith. Staff prompted client to ask about side effects; client was prescribed Lasix and a follow-up was set for 11/3 at 2 PM.

Personal Health & Hygiene

Staff supported client in creating a hygiene checklist and reviewed proper technique for brushing teeth and washing face. Client completed the routine with two verbal reminders.

Money Management / Budgeting

Staff reviewed client's weekly grocery budget and modeled how to calculate item costs before shopping. Client compared prices on three items and identified the lower-cost option independently.

Shopping in a Natural Environment

Staff accompanied client to Walmart and prompted client through following her list and keeping a running total. Client checked expiration dates independently after a demonstration.

For medical appointments, include when relevant: provider name, diagnosis, prescriptions, follow-up appointments, and instructions given.

Skill Areas and Sample Language

Continued — home, cooking, transit, and legal.

Cleaning

Staff demonstrated how to sanitize kitchen counters and supported client in cleaning the sink and stove using disinfectant wipes and gloves. Client completed the stove independently.

Cooking / Meal Preparation

Staff supported client in reading a recipe, identifying needed ingredients, and safely using the stove. Client measured ingredients independently and required prompting for burner safety.

Use of Public Transportation

Staff guided client in using a bus route app to plan a trip to her appointment. Client located the correct route with prompting and practiced transit card use at the stop.

Legal Advocacy

Staff supported client in organizing court paperwork and reviewing upcoming dates. Staff prompted client to identify two questions to ask at his legal consultation.

Draw language from these samples — never copy an entry wholesale. Your note has to describe the session you actually provided.

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Before You Submit

Run through this list before you save the note and clock out.

☐

Am I completing this note before clocking out?

☐

Are the date and times accurate?

☐

If this shift was not in person, did I make the appropriate changes and get supervisor approval?

☐

Did I mark Yes only for goals I actually worked on?

☐

Does each entry explain the skill practiced?

☐

Did I explain what the client did?

Before You Submit

Continued.

☐

Did I explain what staff did, specifically?

☐

Did I document the client's response or progress?

☐

Did I note needed follow-up?

☐

Is my language objective and professional?

☐

Did I avoid any transportation wording?

☐

Could another staff member read this and know what should happen next?

If you answered no to any of these, the note is not finished.

REMEMBER

Good documentation tells the story of the client's ILS services over time.

Your notes should show not just what happened, but how you actively helped the client build independence.

If you have questions or need support with your notes, reach out to your supervisor.

Training Attestation

Every employee completing this training signs the attestation form.

1

Complete the training

Attend the full session and ask questions about anything that is unclear before you sign.

2

Sign the attestation

Confirm your attendance and your understanding of the material, including the acknowledgment items.

3

Keep the handout

Keep the one-page quick reference with you and use it until the checklist is automatic.

Falsifying service documentation is grounds for disciplinary action up to and including termination, and may be reportable to the Regional Center.

Signing the attestation confirms you attended this training and understand what accurate documentation requires.